

I heard Generative AI uses water and is bad. But where does the water go?

Posted by u/Proto-Smilely • 0 points • 22 comments

If it's evaporated it should just come back down right? Or if it's polluted can't we clean it?
Sincerely an AI hater

Comments

u/lreeb • 2 points • 2025-09-20 12:21 UTC

It's just a cheap way of cooling the data centers. It's not an AI exclusive thing, data centers of companies like Amazon, Meta, Reddit, Google, Microsoft and so on have always been bad for the environment, most of them at least. AI just caused an increased demand in data centers with lots of processing power, which caused them to build even more of them.

I find it a bit hypocritical when people turn this into an "AI issue", when in reality, it's about companies with enough money being allowed to do whatever they want, with no regard to the impact on the environment and local communities.

These data centers tend to be just huge cubes with no windows that are using up water, electricity and land without adding any benefits to its surroundings. They often slap them next to some small towns because they can't really fight back or need the money, but long term, it only has negative effects for the area.

What we really need are stricter regulations where data centers can be built and how they're operated. They don't need to be that taxing on the environment, but just taking the "free" resources from the environment is the cheapest option for companies. So unless they're forced to e.g. use renewable energy and closed-loop cooling, they'll just continue like this.

u/Moose_on_a_walk • 1 points • 2025-09-20 11:33 UTC

Think of it like locking up water. Similar to how agriculture or real estate locks up land. The land is still there, but there is now less land for everyone else to use.

FWIW, water is needed for cooling purposes in many types of energy production. AI services requires a lot of power, and thereby water.

u/Aggressive_Size69 • 4 points • 2025-09-20 08:22 UTC

It's not that much that it 'uses up' water, but rather that it reallocates water.

Instead of for example a city getting the water, the AI center gets the water and the city has less water (which also means that the water prices rise). However the water bought by the center stays there,

except for some water that evaporates and goes into the clouds.

Also, AI centers (like most applications) use clean water, not just sea/salt water (of which there is virtually infinite), which costs more energy.

u/Hobbesina • 1 points • 2025-09-20 08:13 UTC

Mozart is a really really bad example, given that he was a court musician for most of his career, and still worked with music after he left court, as a composer and music teacher.

His primary day job was as an artist, a composer... what we remember him for. Had he not been so horrible with finances and had a severe gambling problem, he would have plenty from his art to support himself.

u/ResearcherCritical99 • 4 points • 2025-09-20 07:50 UTC

Climate (long term weather) patterns are hard to change, with climate change increasing droughts & flood intensity, increasing desertification, extreme events, add acidic rain the water evaporated can come in any form or may not come, we're extracting ancient thousands of years old ground water, not a sustainable way to live

u/Hobbesina • 7 points • 2025-09-20 07:36 UTC

Huge amounts of water is used on cooling the data towers used in GAI, and it used in the supply chain of GAI, especially in electricity generation and chip manufacturing.

Some water can be reused (though it isn't drinkable without process), but a large portion evaporates into the atmosphere.

u/KDY_ISD • 9 points • 2025-09-20 07:28 UTC

It may not come down again where you are, and even if it does it may take much longer than the rate you're consuming it at to filter back into the supply.